

PILGRIMAGE BY THE SEA
The Kapil Muni temple at the Gangasagar island in West Bengal

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

donors and is optimistic that the area will evolve into a pilgrim spot. "The government has paid Rs 50 lakh to create a temple like the one in Vaishno Devi. The idea was to have these temples here so that Hindus do not have to travel far to see their cherished temples," says Singh. Needless to say, all this is also an attempt to woo Bengal's Hindi-speaking electorate.

Singh, who hails from UP, has also been given charge of recreating Varanasi's famed Ganga *aarti* on the many ghats of the river Hooghly. Mamata's desire to have *aartis* was prompted by her experience at Varanasi's Dashashwamedh ghat in March 2022, even though some BJP supporters waved black flags and shouted 'Jai Shri Ram' slogans. Singh is now recruiting priests from UP skilled in performing the *aarti*; a Ganga Devi idol will also be installed in a temple to be constructed at Kolkata's Babughat using modern technology from Korea. The project is likely to cost around Rs 2 crore.

This year, too, the TMC government is building five new temples at the pilgrimage site of Gangasagar, on Sagar island, on the Bay of Bengal. Named 'Bengal's Temples: A Spiritual Journey', a 4,000 square feet area has been earmarked for the temples, which will resemble the ones at Kalighat, Tarapeeth, Johura Kali in Malda, Dakshineswar and Tarakeswar. Though the TMC and the district administration are tightlipped about costs, more than a crore is easily being spent. The government has also constructed rooms for the priests of the Kapil Muni ashram at an expense of Rs 65 lakh. All this, it hopes, will attract more tourists. Mamata justifies all the expense saying, "The Centre gives us nothing, not even 10 paise for candies," adding that the Kumbh Mela, by contrast, is flushed with central funds.

IN ITS DEFENCE, THE TMC INSISTS THAT UNLIKE THE BJP'S 'AGGRESSIVE' HINDUTVA, THEIR VERSION IS AN EXERCISE IN INCLUSIVITY

Inaugurating this year's Gangasagar mela, she strove to make a distinction between her Hindu outreach and that of the BJP by invoking progressive, reformist figures. "We believe in the Hindu religion whose path was shown by Ramakrishna Paramhansa and Swami Vivekananda," she said.

All of this has, of course, left the BJP unimpressed. "It's not the job of political parties to construct temples," says BJP MP and party national vice president Dilip Ghosh. "The Ram Mandir is being constructed by people where the prime minister was an invitee visitor. Hindu society is annoyed with Trinamool, so they are imitating us." CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim is even more critical. "Trinamool and BJP are complementary to each other.... Instead of governance or attention to people's basic needs—employment, education, connectivity—the government is engaged in activities that are the responsibilities of religious trusts," he says. "The government is doing Ganga *aarti* on the one hand, whereas the Adi Ganga (once the main channel of the Hooghly) behind Mamata Banerjee's house stinks and is dying of neglect. This is not religiosity but hypocrisy," adds Salim.

However, state tourism and IT minister Babul Supriyo, who was with the BJP earlier, again stresses on what he says is the fundamental difference in the ideologies of the TMC and the BJP. "There's a very big generic difference. BJP as a right-wing party blatantly proclaims that it is only interested in the 70 to 80 per cent majority electorate, thus eliminating a vital section from its scheme of things. In Bengal, the government believes in inclusivity," he says.

Till now, inclusivity in governance and government-sponsored projects across Bengal have been Mamata's stated intention. With her Hindutva push, though, the CM is venturing into uncharted waters. It remains to be seen if her target beneficiaries are taken in by this official religiosity. ■